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THE MELTDOWN IN SRI LANKA

FACED WITH A SERIOUS ECONOMIC CRISIS, THE ISLAND NATION HAS BEEN FORCED TO LOOK OUTWARDS FOR HELP WHICH, IN TURN, IS BURDENING IT WITH HIGH EXTERNAL DEBT

By Namini Wijedasa *in Colombo*

Sri Lanka is wilting under its worst economic crisis in decades. And battered by shortage after shortage, its citizens are enraged.

Snaking queues of sweat-drenched men and women are a familiar sight in every town and city, waiting for cooking gas, kerosene, diesel and petrol. Lining up starts in the early hours and often continues overnight. Pharmacies are running out of even basic medications like antihistamines and paracetamol. Since February, there have been rolling power cuts because foreign exchange reserves, down by 70 per cent in two years, have dwindled to $ 2.3 billion, too low to procure regular fuel imports for transport or thermal power.

Now, the levels in hydropower res-